stadium, as well as the millions watching on TV. That's why all the seniors – Wasim, Waqar, Inzamam – would put their most serious game face on. And it mostly worked.

And then, there were the rivalries. Some personal, some professional. First is the curious case of Gautam Gambhir. Oh, poor Gautam. He and his attitude problem. He, who has no personality. He, who is barely a character in the great scheme of cricket. He, who has no great records, just a lot of attitude. He, who behaves like he's a cross between Don Bradman and James Bond or something. In Karachi, we call guys like him *saryal*, burnt up.

It's simple: I like happy, positive people. Doesn't matter if they are aggressive or competitive on the field. But you have to be positive. Gambhir wasn't.

I remember that run-in with him during the 2007 Asia Cup, when he completed his single while running straight into me. The umpires had to finish it off or I would have. Clearly, we had a frank bilateral discussion about each other's female relatives. Whatever. Gambhir doesn't matter. There are bigger fish to fry when playing India.

It should be noted though, that my bad equation with Gambhir was a one-off. No doubt, my relationship with most Indian players has been great.

So, trust me when I say this about international cricket: body language is one of the most critical components of the modern game. At the international level, everyone's skill sets converge. Everybody has a great strike rate or a great batting average or a great pair of hands. But your eyes are the windows to your confidence. If the opponent looks into them and spots a weakness, you're done.

When you're young and playing a team like India, you move and hustle around a lot in the field. If you're fielding, you go and pat the bowler as he makes his way back for his run-up. You clap hard and chant loudly: for the cameras, for the crowd, for your team, but also for yourself and the guy with the bat. If you're bowling, you extend your follow-through just a little more than usual, go up to the batsman and give him a nice little stare to make him want to go to the washroom or back to his mother.

Your tactic is your tone. Your weapon is your voice. And your eyes are your arsenal.

The idea is to have body language of the sort where the batsman actually says, 'What are you doing, mate? Let me bat in peace, will you?' *That's* when we sense fear creeping up in him. Even if he talks or sledges back at us, there is no stopping, no mercy and no end to the sledging from our end. And if you can't sledge, say, because of an overzealous umpire or something, then you stare him down like you want to eat him, then and there, like he is a piece of meat, and the pitch is a plate. That's *the game*. That's what I did against opponents, especially India, and still believe that if applied well, it can break down any opposition.

However, after many a match against India, there were some players from their side who complained about what on earth we were up to on the field. In response, we told them that it was honestly nothing personal – that's just how we played.

Off the field, however, personal connections were allowed. We used to hang out in each other's rooms – Harbhajan Singh, Yuvraj Singh, Ajay Jadeja – I hung out a lot with them. They're all great guys and we had some great times together. But on the ground, we couldn't stand the sight of each other.

It's not complicated. The rivalry is forever. They are Indians. We are Pakistanis. The end.